

OPTIMISM AND YOUTH

Most of Europe faced a long period of recovery following World War II, but France's fashion industry resurfaced quickly, with the Chambre Syndicale ensuring that the Paris couture houses could open and show collections. On a cold February day in 1947 Christian Dior showed his *La Corolle* collection, sowing the seeds of glamour and creating the basic shape of fashion for the next decade. In Britain clothes rationing lasted until 1950, but Mayfair couturiers such as Hardy Amies produced their version of Dior's "New Look" for English women eager for new styles in a drab post-war world.

Europe and America

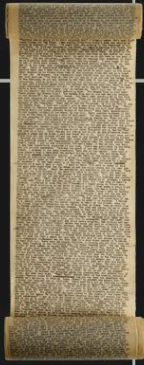
Buyers from North America travelled to Paris to secure toiles (mock-ups of garments) to reproduce "Paris Fashions" in the major department stores back home. In Hollywood, costume designers including Helen Rose and Edith Head were inspired by the styles coming from Paris, and produced their own versions, including the ice-cool, elegant clothes worn by stars like Grace Kelly in Hitchcock's *Rear Window*. There was a connection between Italian style, traditionally excellent for knitwear and printed silk, and American fashion, perhaps through the GIs stationed in Italy during the war, perhaps through mass emigration to the US. Designers in both countries, such as Tina Leser and Claire McCardell in America and Emilio Pucci in Italy, produced stylishly casual clothes, as opposed to the more formal feel of French and British fashion. This easier approach to dressing struck a chord, particularly with younger women.

New consumers

Against the backdrop of an uncertain world haunted by the Cold War and an insidious nuclear threat, young people developed their own culture. A new term was coined – "the teenager" – and they wanted clothes just for themselves. There was a new breed too of cultural hero or role model, men like Elvis Presley who wore leather flight jackets and other military surplus, and young men wanted to look like him. Workwear and denim blue jeans also crossed boundaries and became fashion wear for both young men and young women.



COSTUME DESIGNER
Edith Head designed costumes for film stars including Gloria Swanson, Janet Leigh, and Grace Kelly. She won the Oscar for Best Costume Design eight times.

1947	1948–50	1951–52	
1947 Princess Elizabeth of Great Britain marries Lieutenant Philip Mountbatten; her Norman Hartnell wedding dress is the main topic of conversation.	1948 The 21st academy awards introduces an award for Best Costume Design.	1951 American disc jockey Alan Freed popularizes the term "rock 'n' roll". New teen styles emerge linked to the music, such as "Teddy boys" and prom dresses.	 ◀ Academy award
1949 Dorothy Shaver, president of Lord and Taylor department store, launches a line of casual but elegant sportswear dubbed "The American Look". It is based on an earlier advertising campaign featuring designs by Claire McCardell, Clare Potter, and Bonnie Cashin.	1950 <i>Father of the Bride</i>, starring Spencer Tracy and Elizabeth Taylor, is released. The lace wedding dress worn by Taylor in the film is considered one of her most iconic looks.	1952 Jack Kerouac publishes <i>On the Road</i>, which inspires a generation of beatniks who wear slim-fitting, black clothes, berets, and dark glasses. Audrey Hepburn's <i>Funny Face</i> in 1957 further popularizes the style.	 ▲ Rock-'n'-roll-style, poodle skirt
▲ Christian Dior 1947 Dior shows his first collection, immediately named "The New Look" by American fashion editor Carmel Snow, putting Paris back on the fashion map.	▼ Elizabeth Taylor in <i>Father of the Bride</i> 	► Original scroll manuscript for <i>On the Road</i> 	1952 Balenciaga shows the sack dress, an early stylistic move towards looser-fitting garments, which appear in the late 1950s and 60s, and include cocoon coats and shift dresses.